decreased with the rise of anti-Muslim sentiment in Myanmar.

Despite the attempts from the NLD and Aung San Suu Kyi to discard the 'pro-Muslim' image, such as by expelling party members with temporary residency cards, or 'white card' holders (Yen Snaing 2015) and not selecting a single Muslim candidate (Hindstrom 2015), the Buddhist nationalists endorsed President U Thein Sein and the USDP (Hnin Yadana Zaw and Soldkowski 2015). It was expected that the NLD would win most seats in the election, but was unlikely to gain more than a two-thirds majority needed to form the parliamentary majority outright and the government, taking into account the quarter of seats held by the military.

In the end, the NLD got an absolute majority in both houses of parliament and also in eleven of the fourteen regional assemblies (TNI 2015). It won more than fifty per cent of the seats in five states, and it became the largest party in Kachin State. Many of the ethnic political parties failed to win any seats, either in the national or the regional assemblies of the ethnic majority states. The ethnic parties at the national level did worse than in the controversial 2010 election, going down from fifteen to nine per cent of seats (ICG 2015a, p. 4).

The failure of ethnic parties to get votes, with the notable exception of the Rakhine and Shan States, is explained as being due to a proliferation of parties, lack of resources, weak local politics, failure to translate ethnic identity to votes, the charisma of Aung San Suu Kyi, possible perceptions of these ethnic parties as having close ties with the military, and the effective reach of the national parties at the local level (Burke 2015). The potency of MaBaTha and the importance of Buddhist nationalism in the election were questioned too.

Yet the insights on ethnicity and religion that were underlying the wrong predictions were based on established scholarship on Myanmar. Therefore, the NLD's electoral victory either demands rethinking or rejection of these two assumptions on the roles of ethnicity and religion in Myanmar's politics. This requires us to reconsider the link between an individual's ethnicity, aspects of one's social identity in everyday life, ethnic nationalism, and political mobilization based on the community's ethnic identification. We need to re-apprise the link between the political importance and the cultural ubiquity of Buddhism in Myanmar. But to do that, we need to take into account those elements and conditions in Rakhine State that made it an exception in 2015.